Experiences of Hmong Youth Workers: A Pilot Study to Understand Culturally Appropriate Practice

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Abstract

Hmong immigrants are one of the largest ethnic groups in Minnesota, yet seen as some of the poorest immigrant groups in the United States. In an effort to understand how to support the healthy development of Hmong youth this study explores current youth work practices with Hmong youth. This is a pilot study using semi-structured interviews with 7 youth workers with the purpose of understanding their experiences; and what they saw as important orientation and practices when working with Hmong youth. Themes that came out of the interviews include: families as strong influences in decision making, gender roles and how this impacts relationship, and the issue of cultural isolation and connecting with others. The themes and implications indicate that in order to provide effective youth work for the healthy development of Hmong youth, youth workers will learn that small groups are an effective means for working with Hmong youth, and need to support culturally bound practices.

Introduction

- Minnesota has one of the largest Hmong populations in the United States comprised of generations: refugees, immigrants, and native born.
- Hmong focused agencies have designed informal after school youth programs. In addition, several municipal and non-profit organizations now employ youth workers in part to work with Hmong youth.
- This study seeks to better understand what youth work practices and orientations are most effective with this population.
- The research question used to guide this research included: **What does it look like to be a Hmong youth worker working with Hmong youth?**

Methods

- This qualitative study used semi-structured interviews with adult youth workers (n=7)
- Gender range: 4 Females & 3 Males
- Age range: 18 – 32 years old
- Our study used a convenient sample size to gain information through stories and examples.
- Interviews were audio recorded and transcribed.
- Data was thematically analyzed to formulate themes of the experiences of Hmong youth workers working with Hmong youth.

Discussion

- After two to three generations of being in the U.S., Hmong youth continued to struggle and face similar hardships as new immigrants.
- Sense of Hmong identity and family are still very strong in the Hmong community.



Quotes

"It was totally out of their comfort zone, totally out of their norm for them, so it took a lot (P1).
[in reference to Hmong parents allowing their children to participate in certain programs/activities and the trust needed from Youth workers]

Important as youth supervisor to have communication at all times with the parents and the trust issues they have. This is important to keep programming alive (P2).

Youth while growing up is beginning to learn who they are and beginning to understand their environment and what makes them a leader. A lot it has to do with the messages they receive, such as media. As youth workers, our roles are to help shape youth to understand that there are many positive things they can do (P7).

Whenever they merged, right away there would be a lot of problems like, 'well, the kids are too disruptive so we don't feel our kids are safe.' And the Hmong families pull their kids out because they didn't feel like it was safe (P4)."

Select References

- Picture retrieved from Google (background picture) and Jenny Xiong (forefront picture)
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Results

Our study found these themes to be prevalent among Hmong youth involved in community based youth programs:

1. Primary families strongly influenced the decision making process of children participation in community based youth programs.
2. Gender remained an important construct in relationship of youth worker, youth, and family.
3. Hmong youth born in the U.S. experiences cultural isolation and connecting with others remains an issue.

Limitations

- With a small and purposeful sample size the findings of this pilot research should not be generalized across populations.
- Interpretation of findings may be biased based upon researcher's lived experiences.
- Limited research has been conducted on Hmong youth workers and how to effectively work within that community.

Implications & Recommendations

- Implications include:
  1. Supporting culturally bound practices with an emphasis on family while working with Hmong youth will be more effective.
  2. Small groups are an effective means for working with Hmong youth.
- Recommendations include:
  1. Effective means of retaining Hmong youth in community based youth programs.
  2. Building relationships and trust between Hmong parents and youth workers.
  3. Looking at the identity of native and immigrant for Hmong youth.